

Healing After Incest and Sexual Abuse

A path to healing, with the right support

Support & psychoeducation · resources — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

A path to healing, with the right support

Surviving incest or sexual abuse leaves deep wounds: shame, fear, dissociation, difficulties with the body or relationships. None of this is your fault. Healing is possible — not alone, but supported.

This guide offers support, explains what can help (including EMDR, with a trained therapist), and gives you safe grounding tools. Go at your own pace, and stop if it's too much.

Your intention

If you feel ready — one thing you'd like to see ease, without going into details of what happened:

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

The imprint of trauma (and it's not your fault)

Body and mind keep the memory of what was endured. Your reactions — dissociation, mistrust, hypervigilance, startle — are protections, not flaws. And the shame belongs to the abuser, never to you.

Understanding this is the start of putting down a weight that was never yours.

Example

For a long time, Inès thought her mistrust was 'a problem'. Understanding it was a learned protection changed how she saw herself.

My protections

Which reactions (mistrust, distancing, hypervigilance) actually protected you?

Whom the shame belongs to

Write: 'The shame belongs to the person who harmed me — not to me.'

→ *My reactions are protections — and the shame isn't mine.*

What trauma may have made you believe

'It's my fault', 'I'm damaged', 'I can't trust anyone', 'I'll never recover': these are aftereffects of trauma, not truths about you.

With the right support, these beliefs can ease and transform.

Example

Sure she was 'broken forever', Léa saw, with a therapist's help, that certainty gradually lighten.

An aftereffect belief

Note (gently) a belief trauma installed — without going into details of what happened.

A fairer truth

Across from it, write a fairer, kinder sentence (e.g. 'I'm wounded, not destroyed').

→ *These beliefs are aftereffects — not truths about me.*

Your body, your safety, your worth

Gently and at your pace, you can reclaim your body, your sense of safety and your worth. You have the right to safety, respect, healthy relationships — and, one day, to pleasure.

Your worth is intact. What was done to you took nothing from who you are.

Example

Step by step, with a therapist, Fatou relearned to feel safe in her body. It wasn't linear — but it came.

Gentleness toward myself

Write a sentence of compassion toward who you were — and who you are today.

My rights

Write: 'I have the right to safety, respect and healthy relationships.'

→ *My worth is intact — what was done took nothing from who I am.*

Finding help & grounding safely

Trauma healing happens with a specialized professional. EMDR (trauma-reprocessing therapy) can help a lot — but ALWAYS with a trained therapist, never alone. Other approaches exist (trauma-focused, somatic therapies).

Meanwhile and between sessions, safe grounding tools help you through hard moments: they calm, they don't 'reopen' anything.

Example

With an EMDR-trained therapist, Sofia could, at her pace, ease memories that overwhelmed her — in a safe setting.

My grounding (safe)

Learn 5-4-3-2-1: name 5 things you see, 4 you hear, 3 you touch, 2 you smell, 1 you taste. Use it when anxiety rises.

My support net

Note: a trusted person · a specialized helpline · a trauma therapist to contact.

→ *Grounding safely, and getting support — that's the path.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- None of what happened is your fault — the shame belongs to the abuser.
- Your reactions (dissociation, fear, mistrust) are normal protections to the abnormal.
- Healing is possible, but not solo: a trauma-specialized therapist is the most important support.
- EMDR can help a lot — but ALWAYS with a trained therapist, never alone.
- Learn safe grounding tools (5-4-3-2-1, breathing) for hard moments.
- Go at your pace, stop if it's too much — and you're not alone (helplines below).

To fill in

My grounding

Grounding technique	When to use it

My support net

Person / line / professional	How to reach them

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Remind myself that nothing is my fault.

Week 2 — Soften an aftereffect belief (gently).

Week 3 — A gesture of gentleness toward my body / me.

Week 4 — Seek / contact specialized support.

Your plan in 3 lines

- My sentence: 'The shame isn't mine.'
- My grounding for hard moments:
- The specialized support I contact:

TO CLOSE

Nothing is your fault — and healing is possible, supported.

Nothing is your fault — healing is possible, supported.

This guide is support and psychoeducation for survivors of sexual abuse or incest — it is NOT therapy, nor an EMDR protocol to do on your own (EMDR is ALWAYS done with a trained therapist). Go at your own pace and stop if it's too much. For support, reach out to a specialized sexual-violence helpline or victim-support service in your country; in immediate danger, contact emergency services. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.